cal College and Hospital. He cited 15 counts on which Ghosh's actions seemed suspicious in a letter to the state vigilance commission in July 2023. Apart from the biomedical waste allegation, they included one of the hospital buying (allegedly on the order of the principal), High Flow Nasal Oxygenation machines for Rs 4.3 lakh apiece plus 12 per cent GST during the pandemic. For context, he had pointed to how other city hospitals had bought similar machines for as low as Rs 1.35 lakh apiece.

Meanwhile, in 2023, a lawyer, Akshaya K. Sarangi, filed petitions in the Calcutta HC, demanding Ghosh's removal over the biomedical waste and misuse of corpses charges. In April, the Tala police station registered a plaint from a Biswanath Das, accusing Ghosh of fraud.

So what made Ghosh so powerful? In a conversation with journalists, Opposition leader from the BJP, Suvendu Adhikari, claimed that Ghosh is close to a



Dr Sandip Ghosh

private orthopaedician, Dr Shyama Pada Das, who is allegedly close to CM Mamata. Das is reportedly a member of the 'North Bengal' lobby, which allegedly calls the shots in the state health department. According to sources, MLA Sudipta Roy, along with Susanta Roy, former OSD to the North Bengal Medical College, and Avik Dey—all doctors and members of the West Bengal Medical Council—are part of this lobby. When asked about Ghosh, Sudipta was full of praise. "He is a little strict, but is an able administrator and good teacher," said the MLA who is also chairman of the RG Kar Rogi Kalyan Samiti. When asked about the North Bengal lobby, he didn't deny its existence but said it was called a 'pro-government group' since it won the medical council elections.

CRIMINAL BLUNDER 4

The renovation and the ransacking

On August 13, word spread that the seminar hall, site of the crime scene, was being razed. Protesters—both doctors and political activists—started demanding that the work be stopped immediately. Later, it turned out that some renovation work was being carried out in the room opposite the seminar hall. Arunabha Datta Chaudhuri, former head of the pulmonary medicine department, says work was being done on the orders of ex-principal Sandip Ghosh. "I was on my regular rounds when I heard the noise. I found that portions of the wall had already been broken. I asked them to stop the work immediately," says Chaudhuri. The hurried attempt to carry out construction work near the crime scene has led to claims that it was to erase evidence.

Then, on August 14, even as women were leading a 'Reclaim the Night' march, hundreds of miscreants barged into RGKMCH and proceeded to vandalise the place. They ransacked the emergency room on the ground floor, went up to the second floor, taking down everything in their way and then ransacked the ENT department. Critical medicines and equipment, among several other things, were destroyed. In a video circulating on social media, a miscreant can be heard saying, "Let us go to the seminar room." The nurses and other staff of the hospital took shelter in toilets, the morgue and other places. "One of them threatened to rape us the next time," a female nurse recalls.

The police allegedly did nothing for 20 minutes during the ransacking. Later, they claimed they were outnumbered. Now, the SC has come down heavily on the state police for their inaction and ordered an investigation.



TORN DOWN The room where the work was happening at RGKMCH

↘ Renovation work begins inexplicably on the same floor as the seminar room, site of the gruesome murder

↘ On Aug. 14, miscreants enter the hospital and vandalise it, with the police standing mute. The latter claims they were outnumbered by the '7,000-strong mob'